

The Opportunity Gap

Who actually benefits when AI increases capacity

Abby Buchanan

July 2026

ABSTRACT

AI can reduce the effort required to organize information, communicate ideas, and navigate complex systems. But reducing effort isn't the same as creating opportunity. This memo explores why the benefits AI creates are distributed unevenly—and why its long-term impact may depend as much on institutional design as on the technology itself.

One of the questions I keep coming back to is whether AI creates opportunity, or simply amplifies the opportunities that already exist.

Those aren't the same thing.

If someone finishes a task in half the time because AI helped organize their thinking, summarize information, or draft a first pass, something valuable has been created.

The question is: who gets to keep it?

Sometimes the answer is obvious. A student gaining confidence. A parent reclaiming an hour of mental energy. Someone navigating unfamiliar systems with enough structure to complete something that previously felt impossible.

In those cases, AI doesn't simply increase productivity. It expands what feels possible. But organizations don't always treat efficiency that way.

In many workplaces, time saved doesn't remain with the person who saved it. It becomes the new baseline. Expectations increase. More work fills the space that was created. The individual becomes more productive without necessarily becoming less burdened.

That's a different outcome.

It makes me wonder whether the resource AI creates isn't really time at all. Maybe it's cognitive margin. The ability to pause before responding. To think instead of reacting immediately. To make connections instead of simply keeping up.

That kind of capacity has always been unevenly distributed.

People with financial stability, supportive workplaces, flexible schedules, and strong professional networks often have more of it. People navigating economic pressure, caregiving responsibilities, disability, burnout, or institutional complexity often have less.

AI has the potential to shift those conditions.

It can reduce some of the translation work modern systems require. It can lower the effort needed to organize ideas, communicate clearly, and navigate unfamiliar processes. But none of that guarantees a different outcome.

If the additional capacity AI creates is consistently absorbed by employers, institutions, or systems that simply ask for more, then the technology may increase efficiency without meaningfully expanding opportunity.

If that capacity remains with individuals, the story looks very different. People may have more room to learn. More room to recover. More room to contribute in ways they couldn't before.

The future of AI isn't only about what these tools can do.

It's also about who gets to benefit from what they make possible.

I'm interested in how we design systems that make those opportunity gaps narrower instead of wider.